

2.6.2 Virtual Consoles

Strictly speaking, a console is nothing but an input and output device—a keyboard and a monitor. Simple as that. Remember we said UNIX was made to be a multi-user system where several users were connected to a single mainframe? Each user was only given a console connected to the mainframe. But with the advent of PCs, the need for consoles has diminished (actually, eliminated, except in legacy systems) and Linux only gives a feel of a console by way of a Virtual Console. It's called so because on a single system, you are allowed to log in as different users, thus simulating a console environment.

This can be very useful because you can implement tasks corresponding to different users simultaneously. Generally four to seven virtual consoles are provided, extendable up to 12. You just need to press `[Alt] + [F2]`, and you will be prompted to enter a second user name and password (you are already logged in as the first user, mind you!). You then enter the second console. Press `[Alt] + [F3]` and you get yet another, similar window for the third console. Thus you can configure to have up to 12 virtual consoles (12 is as many function keys as you have!).

Shifting between virtual consoles can be done even by using the directional arrows with `[Alt]` pressed.

To move to the next console, press `[Alt] + [>]`

To move to the previous console, press `[Alt] + [<]`